the edict-bearing shelter lies in the Rehti reserved forest, in the midst of jungle foliage and spectacular scenic views of the surrounding landscape. An uneven back wall within the shelter shows the writing. Part of the rock seems to have been found unsuitable by the engraver. So he set down the epigraph in two parts, three lines of writing in the first part and five lines in the second.[49]

There is a further distinction: Ashoka directly addresses the local governor, a Kumara called Samva.[50] Such direct communication is not evident at Maski, Brahmagiri, or any other Ashokan location at this point in time. All who read or heard the Panguraria message, as we do today, would have learnt that the governor was the recipient of a message from the king himself. The governor's title, 'kumara', meant he was a scion of the royal family though not a son of the king—as was the 'aryaputra' in Karnataka.

The place from where the king sent his message is also provided, for the first time. Ashoka is communicating with Kumara Samva 'from his march to the Upunita-vihara in Manema-desha'. Upunita-vihara was a Buddhist monastery, though it has not been identified on the ground; nor has the territorial unit referred to as Manema-desha. Even so, that the emperor was journeying to reach a vihara offers a precious hint about some of the places that he was heading for during his long tour of 256 nights (or days). This then prompts us to wonder about the reactions of resident Buddhist monks and nuns in such viharas to the royal visitor and his entourage. The man appearing on the horizon will have been perceived as the first monarch to be touring his kingdom not to consolidate it materially but to extend it spiritually. His extraordinariness will have seemed to many to border on the peculiar.